

MORE WAYS TO CONNECT THAN EVER. LESS CONNECTION.

Twenty conversations on how young adults connect socially — and why the bar keeps winning.

Picture kids at recess where everyone is crowded onto **the playground**. It isn't much fun, but it's reliable so nobody leaves. Around the edges people call out the games they'd rather be playing — *flag football, jump rope, dance off* — but nobody moves, because the fun was never in the game. It's in the density.

The playground is the bar.

We didn't choose it.

We inherited it.

73-79%

of Gen Z report loneliness,
the highest of any generation

6.5 → 4

hours a week with friends,
2014–2019 (**before** COVID)

50%

of 18–34s drink — from the
likeliest age group to the least

Lacking social connection carries
the mortality risk of smoking

15 cigarettes a day

METHOD | **SAMPLE** (n = 20) · **AGES** (23–28) · **GENDER** (14 men, 6 women) · **CITIES** (7) · **QUESTIONS** (7, open-ended)

0/20

Not one person made a friend at a bar.

Every setting they named was one they went back to.

- **New people, yes. Strangers, no.** Every path to meeting someone new ran through someone they already knew.
- **Friend groups don't merge.** The problem isn't that people are alone. It's that the groups never touch.
- **Discovery is not the bottleneck.** People are flooded with options, not starved. Another events feed solves a problem nobody has.
- **Technology = good at logistics, bad at people.** "It's easy to find things to do. Not as easy to find people to do them with." — 28, New York.
- **Partiful is the only app anyone volunteered as useful.** It organizes the invite, but not the occasion, so you end up talking to the people you came with.
- **Everyone described the same perfect day:** a quiet morning, something active with friends, a shared meal, games at night. Alcohol is never the point.

THE 5 CORE PROBLEMS

1. Finding **the right people** who want to do the same things.
2. Finding **new, fun things** to do — easily.
3. **Starting conversations** with people you don't know.
4. **Not trusting** that events or apps have the right people.
5. **Cost and coordination** — free, close, schedulable.

*People don't go out to drink,
they go out to connect!*

"There are a million things happening, then I get overwhelmed, and then I don't know anyone going — so it feels like there is nothing."

— 24, LOS ANGELES —

OUR GENERATION WANTS COMMUNITY, BUT WE LACK THE INFRASTRUCTURE. *So let's build it.*